# A LIFE WELL LIVED

**The journey of a visionary who transformed the Tata Group into a global conglomerate, leaving an indelible mark on India's business landscape**



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



**1937** Ratan Naval Tata is born on Dec. 28 in Mumbai. Grows up at Tata Palace, the Bombay home of his grandmother, Lady Navajbai. Schooling at Campion, Cathedral and John Connon in Mumbai, then Bishop Cotton in Shimla

**1955** Goes to Riverdale Country School in New York state and then to Cornell; initially pursues a degree in Mechanical Engineering but later graduates with BA in Architecture in 1962



**1962** Returns to India, joins as an assistant in Tata Industries; spends six months training at the Jamshedpur plant of Tata Engineering and Locomotive Company, or Telco (now called Tata Motors)



**1963-65** Joins TISCO (now Tata Steel) in Jamshedpur, initially as a trainee, later a technical officer

**1969** Works as the Group's resident representative in Australia

**1970** Returns to India for a brief stint at Tata Consultancy Services (TCS)



**1974** Joins Tata Sons as a Director

**1981** Becomes Chairman of Tata Industries. Later, drafts the strategic plan towards high-technology enterprises

**1986-89** Becomes Air India Chairman

because his grandmother, Lady Navajbai Tata, wanted him back. She was the one who brought him and his brother Jimmy up ever since their parents had separated, and she was getting old.

Two weeks after returning to India, he was sent to the Jamshedpur plant of Telco (now Tata Motors ) as an apprentice and later to Tisco (now Tata Steel) to hone his skills. He seemed to have forged his own work ethic then, rolling up his sleeves on the shop floor and sharing meals with the workers in the canteen. In retrospect, it would seem some of that steel rubbed off on him—along with the simplicity and lack of humbug from his mates.

When Ratan Tata took over from JRD, it was the dawn of liberalisation in India and there were conflicting currents of enterprise and protectionism. Tata's instinct was to venture outward, towards the global stage, rather than inward. The Tata Group was then still a loose confederation of companies, but bound by common synergies with the centre (read, Tata Sons) giving it strategic leadership. In his early years as helmsman, he laid down his motto: that the group was more important than individual companies. That meant, to unify the command structure and attain coherence of purpose, he had to sack an array of Tata satraps like Russi Mody, Ajit Kerkar and Darbari Seth who ran their own "fiefdoms".

It was also necessary to make the